

happens in *Rashomon*'s glade: four people witness a simple chain of events, but they interpret it through the filter of their own imaginations. Each of them transforms what they have seen into a story. These stories are not lies, however, but tricks of the mind—indeed, with *Rashomon*, Kurosawa suggests that there is no such thing as objective truth.

Since the movie's release in 1950, the primary storytelling device of *Rashomon* has been borrowed and imitated countless times, from the American remake in 1964, *The Outrage*, a Western starring Paul Newman, to the

sleight-of-hand potboiler plots of *The Usual Suspects* (1995) and *Gone Girl* (2014). However, rarely do the imitators dare to withhold a satisfying solution, as Kurosawa does at the end of his masterpiece. We never find out who killed the samurai, nor what really happened between the woman and the bandit, but we do see the characters change as they sift through their own recollections.

The Rashomon effect

The "*Rashomon* effect" has entered language as shorthand for any situation, in art or life, in which the

truth remains elusive because no one can agree on what happened. What is certain is that *Rashomon* was one of the most influential movies of the 20th century. It set box-office records for a subtitled movie and acted as a gateway through which Western moviegoers could look for the first time at the beguiling, unfamiliar world of Japanese cinema. And each of those moviegoers would have seen something different. ■

In the wife's story, she offers her husband a knife to kill her after she sees a look of disgust on his face following the rape.

